Army Issue Elf

By Paul Feig

PAUL: **(Pg 9 +)** I was selected to play the lead elf in my school's Christmas pageant when I was in the first grade. The only reason I got the part was because my voice was louder and better suited to be heard in a cavernous gymnasium than any other kid in my class.

I don't really remember the specifics of my recruitment into the world of theater. I just remember that one day I came home and told my mother I needed an elf costume.

INTRODUCTION

Dear Mr. and Mrs. Feig: The 1st grade classes will be performing in a Christmas play on Thursday, December 19th at 3:00 pm. Please mark this date in your calendars. Your child has an important part in the program, so please make sure he has his elf costume ready and with him for the production. Thank you . . . Miss Conner.

And so the saga of the Army Issue Elf by Paul Feig begins.

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MOM: An elf costume? Hmmm . . .

PAUL: She and I had seen plenty of TV shows and commercials with elves in them. We'd watched the perennially creepy *Rudolph the Red-Nosed Reindeer* on TV together at Christmas time enough for her to know what one of Santa's miniature helpers wore. When my father came home that night, my mother informed him of my wardrobe needs.

FATHER: *(annoyed)* An ***elf****?* How are we supposed to do *that?*

NARRATOR*: [Now],* my father owned an army surplus store called Ark Surplus. If a kid's father could own any kind of business, an army-surplus store is about as good as it gets, falling short only of a toy company or a roller-coaster factory. As a first grader who was simply trying to get an elf costume for the Christmas pageant, I knew exactly where that costume was going to be pieced together.

FATHER: *(sighing)*"All right. I'll take him down to the store this weekend and we'll figure something out.

PAUL: A few days later, we went into Ark Surplus and

started scouring the aisles for anything that was vaguely elflike.

FATHER: What kind of pants do elves wear? *(poking through a shelf)*

MOM: I think they wear shorts.

PAUL: Yeah! They wear shorts with suspenders. *(to audience)* I don't know why my parents didn't try to find a book that had a picture of an elf in it that they could have used for reference. But my parents felt they could pull an elf costume out of all this former soldier gear. And I had no choice but to trust them.

We came home that afternoon with a bag full of army issued goods. The search for elf shorts resulted in my father's grabbing a pair of olive drab (or "O.D.") green U.S. government boxer shorts and two black nylon straps. These straps were usually used to lash down an ammunition box but were now going to serve as my merry suspenders. The question of footwear had stumped all three of us, and so a long pair of O.D. green socks and a lengthy piece of foam rubber

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had been harvested in the hopes of approximating an elf shoe.

FATHER: *(with determination)* Okay, let's get to work.

PAUL: He and my mother went about constructing my elf outfit. I put on a white button-up shirt from my closet and stepped into the army boxers, which my mother then hoisted up, practically lifting me off the ground and giving me an army-issue wedgie. My father took the black nylon straps and taped the ends inside the front and back of the boxers, creating a suspender-like effect.

FATHER: What the hell do elves' feet look like anyway?

PAUL: They have shoes that curl up.

MOM: *(as if that were absurd)* I think it's their ***feet*** that curl up.

PAUL: My father thought for a second, then grabbed a knife and went to work on the piece of foam rubber. He cut two large banana-shaped curls that were almost a foot long and then stuffed one inside the toe of each sock.

I pulled the socks on and stood up. My feet now looked like two dark green pontoons. Instead of

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curling upward, they gently rose at about a fifteen-degree angle. In addition, my feet were now each about twenty-four inches long.

FATHER: *(nodding his approval)* Those look like elf feet to me!

PAUL: My mother pulled the watch cap down onto my head and then she and my father stepped back to inspect me.

MOM: *(excitedly)* I know what's missing! *(she exits)*

FATHER: *(insulted by the casting)* Why are you playing an elf anyway?

PAUL: I don't know . . . I guess they think I look like one. *(to audience)* Before my father's disapproval could scar me for life, my mother ran back in with some cotton balls and a bottle of Elmer's glue and proceeded to put glue on three cotton balls. She took two of them and put one on the toe of each sock. Then she took the third cotton ball and stuck it on top of my hat.

MOM: ***Now*** he looks like an elf.

PAUL: My parents stared at me. Several seconds passed. All of a sudden . . . *(Mom breaks out in laughter and Dad too)* and soon my parents were sitting on the floor, helpless with hysterics. I knew tomorrow would not be a good day.

I headed off to school the next morning with my costume in a paper grocery bag. Since I had been blessed with a loud voice and good speaking skills, I was to portray the skeptical elf, for whom the pageant was being held. My character apparently had problems deciphering what the true spirit of Christmas was and it was up to everyone else in the show to convince me that Christmas wasn't just about presents and food. Which was ironic because **to** every single one of us in that elementary school, presents and food were ***exactly*** what Christmas was all about.

(to Brian) What's your elf costume look like?

BRIAN: *(shrugging)* I don't know. It's pretty stupid.

PAUL: I started polling the other kids in the class. They all seemed to think that their costumes were not really very elflike. I started to take heart. Maybe my costume wasn't so bad. True, I looked a little more combat-ready than any elf I'd ever seen but,

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maybe I was going to be okay.

After lunch, our teacher, Miss Connor, informed us it was time to change into our costumes and get ready for the pageant. Out of every bag, my peers produced gaily colored costumes. Bright reds and greens and crisp clean whites made the room glow. And everyone had shoes that looked like they came from a Hollywood studio costume department. These were the most realistic-looking elf costumes I had ever seen, better than the ones worn by the teenagers who worked at the mall and dragged you over to Santa to have your picture taken. And it was in this atmosphere that I pulled out my United States military elf attire.

BRIAN: *(in disgust)* What color is ***that****?*

PAUL: *(defensively)* It's O.D. green. *(disdainfully)* O. D. stands for ***olive drab.***

MIKE: Elves aren't that color. You're gonna look like a booger.

PAUL: I put on my outfit and became the focal point of the room.

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BRIAN: What's wrong with your feet?!

PAUL: They're elf feet. They're ***supposed*** to be big.

BRIAN: Elves' feet aren't big. Their ***shoes*** are big.

PAUL: No they're not. It's their ***feet****.* They're big and curly. My mom said so.

BRIAN: Well, your mom is wrong.

PAUL: *(to audience)* Miss Connor came back into the room and looked us all over.

MISS CONNER: Very nice. You all look wonderful. *(then she sees our narrator)* Oh . . . my!

MIKE: He doesn't look like an elf, does he, Miss Connor*?*

MISS CONNER: I don't know. I think he looks exactly like the kind of elf who would have doubts about Christmas.

PAUL: Miss Connor was now the love of my life! [She] brought us out into the hallway, where the girls were waiting. When [they] spotted me, they stared in disbelief. *(to the girls, haughtily)* I'm an elf who doesn't know the meaning of Christmas. I'm ***supposed*** to look this way!

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MICHELLE: You look like a booger that doesn't know the meaning of Christmas. *(laughing)*

PAUL: It got a huge laugh from both the girls and the guys. One thing's for certain in grade school-a booger joke will ***always*** land well with your audience.

MISS CONNER: *(remembering)* Oh, shoot. I was supposed to tell Mr. Kavich's class to come down to the gym in five minutes. Paul, run down to their room and tell them, would you?

PAUL: My heart sank. It was the last thing I wanted to do. Mr. Kavich's class was sixth grade. Even though I knew they were soon to see me in the pageant festooned in my government-surplus elf gear, there was something about their seeing me out of context that I knew spelled trouble.

MISS CONNER: Hurry up. If we forget, we won't have any upperclassmen in the audience. *(smiling)*

PAUL: *(looking like a love-sick puppy)* Having crushes on teachers is the surest way of relinquishing any and all power over your dignity when you're a kid.

I smiled at her and ran off to deliver my message. I

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slid up in front of Mr. Kavich's classroom door. I could hear him lecturing behind it. Feeling very cool to be seconds away from entering a sixth-grade classroom as a lowly first grader, I opened the door and stepped inside. That was as far as I got. *(laughter from everyone)*

As I stood there, watching both the students and Mr. Kavich become helpless with laughter, I pondered whether this was the kind of joy and goodwill I, as an elf, was supposed to be bringing to the world. I was definitely taking one for Santa's team.

The pageant was a blur to me. There are unsettling home movies from the event. Behind me in a sloppy line are my fellow elves, fidgeting and shifting their weight and picking their noses and engaging in general unprofessional stagecraft. *(proudly)* I, on the other hand, had overcome the handicap of my costume, the mockery of my peers and schoolmates, the stifled laughter of every teacher and parent in the audience, and I discovered the ***true*** meaning of Christmas. I had learned that it was about

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more than just clothes and presents and decorations. And [I] hadn't done it for them, not for [myself], and, no, not even for Santa. No, the skeptical surplus elf had done it all for one thing and one thing only . . . The United States Army. *(salute)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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